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Title:
## How to Ride a Motorcycle (Badly)

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Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

a division of
BIG RODENT PRODUCTIONS
Orlando, FL

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**How to Ride a Motorcycle (Badly)**
A Dramatic Interpretation (Male)
By Clint Snyder

STEVE

My father's death wasn't spectacular. It wasn't the type of death that you would see in a movie, but in my head I still like to convince myself that he died in some grand Shakespearean way, like poison or a swordfight to the death. Prior to this he would recite a ten minute monologue explaining everything I've ever wanted to hear and tying up all his loose ends. In reality, he died in a hospital bed and his last words to me were, "Change the channel backs to ESPN you pansy." Then he coughed a few times and died, but I convinced myself for at least a few minutes that he was still alive, so I told a joke after he died. I have the unfortunate habit of making awful jokes when I get uncomfortable. (Pause.) "Hey two cannibals are eating a clown and one asks the other "Does this taste funny to you?"" (Uncomfortable laugh.) I find the jokes on Popsicle sticks and I save them all in a dresser drawer. Dad called me that a few times, "Popsicle stick". I'm not completely sure what he meant. That I'm skinny, I guess. The only thing that could have possibly made the situation more awkward, and did, was finding out that an answer to a question I never wanted answered. In case you were wondering, "Yes, people do relieve themselves when they die, but that's my life, one awkward moment after the next. The only time that I can remember that was even more awkward was shortly after, on my newly purchased motorcycle, trying not to crash into every car Harlem avenue on the way to my father's funeral. (Suggested intro place/ end of teaser) I started growing up like any other kid, playing little league for a while, karate, hockey. My dad put me in about every sport known to man. I'd be in it for a few weeks,

until I had worn down each coach enough to beg my father to let me quit. "We'll find something that you're good at." He would tell me. I already had- I was clearly the best artist in my class. At six years old my macaroni portraits would make Van Gogh cry himself to sleep after realizing just how bad he was. I had given one to my dad, a T-rex biting the neck off a cheetah on the moon, quite spectacular if I say so myself. I found it in the trash the next morning. What he meant was, "We'll find something that you're good at that Chuck Norris might also be good at." Walker Texas Ranger was his favorite show. Technically, Chuck Norris is an actor, most actors did theatre, and I don't think theatre qualifies under Dad's list of "Things Men Should do", but I chose not to remind him of this fact.

By the time I got older, I think he had finally given up. I had worn him down the same way I wore down those coaches and my tight, but fashionable bell bottom jeans. He would talk a lot about his friend's sons and all the amazing things they were doing, like killing deer and buying cars. "Did you know that Doug's son got two turkeys on their last weekend trip." "No, that's… great." I lied a lot to my dad. As far as I was concerned Doug's son was a turkey. I guess he sort of "mentally adopted" them, as a way of making up for me being such a failure. I tried to revive his faith every now and then by watching a football game with him or a John Wayne movie. He saw right through me though, whenever someone made a touchdown and he would start shouting at the t.v. like he was trying to somehow channel his aggression to the players through the t.v. I would make a comment like, "Yeah, he was… fast." Then it would get uncomfortable and I would start making Popsicle jokes. "Two cookies were sitting in an oven together. One cookie says, "is it just me or is it getting warm? The other one says, "Ahhh, A talking cookie." (Laughs uncomfortably.)

A few years after I made that joke we found out he had prostate cancer. He forgot to flush one time and my mom found some blood in his pee. She wasn't really a forceful woman, but she had a quiet way of getting what she wanted and she wanted him to go to the doctor.

My dad compared women to furniture one time. I've always thought of it as just another sexist rant, but after the doctors told my dad I remember my mom's eyes were wet and tense with pain. I focused on her eyes hard to stop myself from allowing myself to feel the gravity of what was happening, that must have been what my dad had done too because his face hardly moved at all until he shouted, "Maybe you should have learned something at med school instead of wasting your parents money!" He stormed out and we followed my mother raining tears the whole way home.

He tried to convince everyone, including himself, that he was fine. To him, prostate cancer was like the ultimate insult. It emasculated him… he must have felt… like me. So he tried to pretend it didn't exist. It worked for a while, but he eventually got so weak he couldn't ignore it anymore. He got taken to the hospital. He laid in that hospital bed for two months complaining to everyone who would listen about anything he could think of. Then he died. No meaningful last words. No dignity. No manhood. No son... not the way he wanted anyway.

I went home and did the only sensible thing a man like me could do. I locked myself in the bathroom and cried. What was worse, I watched myself cry. Standing there, weak, pale, he must have looked just like me before he died. I think that was the biggest slap in the face for him. He used to say, "Always look like you're ready to fight someone, it shows confidence." I stood looking at myself in the mirror imagined my peach fuzz turning into thick black curls, my limp body becomes bulging muscles and I'm wearing

the kind of hat Clint Eastwood would kill someone in. ( Stand straighter, with new strength.)

Then it came to me. I'd buy a motorcycle and drive it to his funeral. It wasn't exactly a horse, but I think dad would have approved. It was the kind of testosterone packed choice that might have made him change his mind about me. The man I bought it from asked me if I had a motorcycle license. I didn't even know I needed one. "Of course I have one." That's not something the old me would have done, but I think the danger of driving without a license was just the kind of move and that was what I was going for. I drove it all the way to the funeral, if you could call it driving. I almost got into about six accidents and I'm pretty sure someone had to have reported me, but it was important. It was important to him. I cried, but I was wearing sunglasses, so no one would see, which made it more difficult to drive. Everyone stared at me when I got off the motorcycle, but probably because it took me ten minutes to park. After that everything happened so fast. The priest said a few words, mom cried a lot and everyone threw some cheap gas station flowers onto the cheap coffin while the cheap undertaker looked upset about his cheap job. They lowered him into the ground and I went home on my seven hundred pound mechanical beast that I was trying way too hard to tame. I can't believe I had to try so hard to do something every sloppy redneck half-way across the country could do blind-folded.

Days later I still had his death fresh in my head. I couldn't get him out. I just wanted to be done. I thought it must have been because the stupid mechanical beast in the garage was there reminding me of him, so I "drove", and I use that term loosely, to a field with nobody around in circles until the gas was all gone. I brought a small container of gas with me, but instead of pouring it in the tank I dumped it all over the bike and set it on fire. I wanted this gone, not just the bike, but that part of my life. I wanted him out of

my head. It was like he was my cancer that ate its way into my system and spread throughout my body until every single choice, every move I make was dictated by him, even after he died. Why couldn't this just die with him?

I thought that would kill it. His voice ringing in my head, but it was still there and I came to a realization. It was ringing louder and louder until the flames grew higher and higher. They reached they reached what was left of the small gas container and pop. The explosion forced me backwards and flashed a short bright light and licked my face with hot flames. I lay there in the tall grass a moment completely unharmed, but changed. I came to a realization. My mind became clear as I stared at the clear sky. There was more to my dad than the disappointment. I had spent so long focusing on how I could not be what he wanted me to be. There were plenty of times where he just let that melt away and loved me for who I was. It was time for me to forgive my father and time for me to forgive myself. It took my father's death for me to realize that he did love me, but in truth I had to learn to love myself before I could let anyone love me and that for everyone's sake I should never try to ride a motorcycle again. (Smiles.)